

Goldman Sachs Operations

A practical operations analyst simulation covering foundational transaction planning and the resolution of a time-sensitive UHNW trade-fail.

Task 1 · Foundations of Operations

Task 2 · Facilitating UHNW Transactions

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Data & Finance Analytics

Issued by Forage
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Verified Certificate

About the simulation

The Goldman Sachs **Operations Job Simulation** on Forage recreates the day-to-day work of an operations analyst supporting Private Wealth Management. It spans two hands-on tasks: building a **personal transaction plan** that underpins sound banking operations, and investigating a **trade-fail** for an ultra-high-net-worth (UHNW) client where a time-sensitive purchase is at risk. The work below reproduces both deliverables in full.

Task 1 • Foundations of Operations

Built a structured Personal Transaction Plan covering budgeting, banking accuracy checks, transaction monitoring, business enablement and timely payments, the operational backbone for handling client instructions.

Task 2 • Facilitating UHNW Transactions

Diagnosed pending settlements and trade-booking sign errors for a UHNW client, quantified a -\$4.6M net shortfall against a time-sensitive art purchase, and produced a full Trade Fail Report.

Skills demonstrated

Trade settlement & reconciliation · sign-convention validation · risk assessment · cross-team escalation (Trading Desk, Compliance, IT) · client-relationship risk management.

Outcome

Identified 6 blocked transactions and a \$9.6M reporting swing from mis-signed Buy trades; recommended automated validation controls and a UHNW time-sensitive-transaction protocol.

Personal Transaction Plan

Managing essential monthly subscriptions (AI tools, gym, music, mobile plan, stock investment) for productivity, lifestyle, and long-term savings

MONTHLY INCOME £125	FIXED SUBSCRIPTIONS £65	BUDGET CAP £100/mo	MONTHLY SAVINGS £10
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Constraints: Must stay within £100/month total subscription budget; funded by family support of £100-150/month; prioritise necessity and productivity over discretionary spending

Monthly expense breakdown

ITEM	AMOUNT
AI Subscription (Productivity)	£15
Gym Membership (Lifestyle)	£25
SoundCloud (Entertainment)	£10
Lebara SIM (Necessity)	£5
Stock Investment Plan (Savings)	£10
Transport (Variable)	£22.50
Groceries (Variable, ~£6.50/day)	£195
Eating Out (Variable)	£12.50
Gym Supplements (One-off/Periodic)	£45
Total Fixed Subscriptions	£65
Total All Expenses	£340

Budget adjustments: Downgrade or cancel discretionary subscriptions if variable costs exceed budget; use annual billing where cheaper

Operational controls

Banking Processes

Accuracy check: Verified, all account details (address, phone, email) are accurate and up to date. Regular checks conducted.

Updates made: No updates required at this time. Account information reviewed and confirmed current.

Transaction Monitoring

Discrepancies: Occasional discrepancies identified through regular transaction reviews (e.g., incorrect charges, duplicate debits). Flagged promptly.

Actions taken: Disputed incorrect charges with the provider/bank and successfully obtained refunds. Use dummy cards for free trials to prevent accidental charges on main account.

Business Enablement

Variable spending (groceries, transport, eating out) is not tracked systematically on a daily basis

Fix: Implement a daily expense logging habit using a budgeting app or simple spreadsheet to track variable costs in real time

No consolidated monthly spending review, reliance on memory for low subscription count

Fix: Set up a monthly end-of-month review to compare actual vs. budgeted spend and identify trends or areas to cut back

Timely Payments

On auto-debit with monthly reminders:

- AI Subscription
- Gym Membership
- SoundCloud
- Lebara SIM
- Stock Investment Plan

Variable expenses (transport, groceries, eating out) are paid ad hoc and not on auto-debit

Reflective summary

What worked well

Automating all fixed subscriptions via direct debit eliminated late payment risk and reduced cognitive load. Using dummy cards for free trials prevents accidental charges, a strong risk mitigation practice. Regular transaction monitoring has successfully caught errors and recovered funds through refunds.

Areas for improvement

Daily tracking of variable expenses (groceries, transport, eating out) is inconsistent. Without systematic logging, it is difficult to identify spending patterns or optimise the variable portion of the budget. A structured daily tracking habit or budgeting app would address this gap.

Key insights & lessons

Operational efficiency in personal finance mirrors corporate operations: automation reduces manual error, reconciliation catches discrepancies early, and proactive monitoring is more effective than reactive corrections. The biggest insight is that even a well-automated system benefits from periodic review, the equivalent of an operational audit, to ensure spending aligns with evolving priorities.

Trade Fail Report

DATE 6 August 2026	ANALYST Dhruv Kamdar	CLIENT UHNW · time-sensitive art purchase
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01 Summary of Identified Issues

- Issue 1:** Six transactions (TXN001, TXN003, TXN004, TXN006, TXN008, TXN010) remain in “Pending” status due to various operational blocks: awaiting funds transfer, compliance review hold, technical system issue, pending internal approval, insufficient funds, and missing documentation. These unresolved transactions prevent timely settlement and fund access.
- Issue 2:** Trade booking errors on TXN005 (Buy, +\$3,000,000) and TXN009 (Buy, +\$1,800,000). Both are Buy transactions recorded with positive amounts, violating the standard sign convention where Buy = cash outflow = negative. This misrepresents the client’s true cash position and distorts portfolio reporting.
- Issue 3:** After correcting for the sign convention errors, the client’s net fund position is -\$4,600,000. The client has no funds available to complete the time-sensitive purchase of the Murakami painting, creating immediate financial and relationship risks.

02 Actions Taken

- Action for Issue 1:** Flagged all six pending transactions and categorised each by root cause. Escalated TXN001 and TXN008 (funds transfer/availability) to the Trading Desk. Referred TXN003 (compliance review) and TXN010 (missing documentation) to Compliance and Risk Management. Routed TXN004 (technical issue) to the IT Department. Escalated TXN006 (awaiting approval) to Trading Desk and Compliance for clarification on the type of approval required.
- Action for Issue 2:** Identified the sign convention discrepancy on TXN005 and TXN009 by cross-referencing all Buy transactions. Escalated to the Trading Desk for correction of the trade booking records. Adjusted the total funds calculation to treat both as negative outflows, revealing the true net position.
- Action for Issue 3:** Consulted with a senior colleague to determine the purchase price of the Murakami painting and to identify alternative funding sources available to the client, such as lombard lending facilities, liquidation of settled positions, other custody accounts, or a letter of credit, all without triggering regulatory breaches or incurring unnecessary financial loss.

03

Teams Involved

Team for Issue 1: Trading Desk (TXN001 - funds transfer, TXN006 - approval, TXN008 - funds not available), Compliance and Risk Management (TXN003 - compliance review, TXN006 - approval, TXN010 - documentation), IT Department (TXN004 - technical issue).

Team for Issue 2: Trading Desk responsible for correcting the trade booking entries on TXN005 and TXN009 to reflect the proper negative convention for Buy transactions.

Team for Issue 3: Senior Operations Management and the Relationship Manager, to confirm the painting's purchase price of the painting, assess alternative funding sources, and coordinate a resolution path that preserves the client relationship.

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Risk Assessment

Risk for Issue 1: Financial Loss - Unresolved pending transactions prevent fund settlement, potentially causing the client to miss the purchase window. The painting's price may increase, or a deposit may be forfeited. Client Dissatisfaction: Failure to execute a time-sensitive purchase for a UHNW client damages trust and risks the broader client relationship, which in PWM is far more costly than any single transaction.

Risk for Issue 2: Financial Reporting Risk- Incorrectly signed trade entries misrepresent the client's cash position by \$9,600,000 (the swing between recording both as +\$4.8M vs -\$4.8M). This could lead to erroneous investment decisions, inaccurate portfolio valuations, and potential regulatory reporting discrepancies.

Risk for Issue 3: Regulatory Breach - There is a temptation to expedite the compliance-held transactions (TXN003, TXN010) to free up funds quickly. Rushing compliance or documentation checks to meet the client's timeline could result in KYC/AML violations and regulatory penalties for the firm.

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Mitigation Strategies

Mitigation for Issue 1: Assign a dedicated coordinator to track each pending transaction in parallel rather than sequentially. Set a 24-hour resolution SLA for each blocking issue. Establish direct communication channels with the Trading Desk, IT, and Compliance teams to accelerate resolution without bypassing controls.

Mitigation for Issue 2: Request the Trading Desk to amend TXN005 and TXN009 immediately. Implement a pre-settlement validation check that flags any Buy transaction recorded with a positive amount before it reaches "Completed" status, preventing recurrence.

Mitigation for Issue 3: Work with the Relationship Manager to identify bridge funding options (lombard loan, margin facility, or redeployment of settled positions) so the purchase can proceed while pending transactions are resolved through proper channels. Ensure all compliance reviews (TXN003, TXN010) follow standard timelines and do not expedite at the cost of regulatory integrity.

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Follow-Up Actions

Follow-Up for Issue 1: Monitor the status of all six pending transactions daily until settled. Confirm with each responsible team that resolution is on track. Provide the client's Relationship Manager with a status update within 24 hours.

Follow-Up for Issue 2: Verify that the Trading Desk has corrected TXN005 and TXN009 entries. Reconcile the corrected figures against the client's portfolio records. Conduct a retrospective review of all recent Buy transactions across Client A and Client B accounts to check for additional sign errors.

Follow-Up for Issue 3: Confirm the painting's purchase price with the Relationship Manager. If bridge funding is arranged, document the facility terms and ensure the client's approval. Schedule a post-resolution debrief with all involved teams to capture lessons learned.

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Recommendations

Recommendation for Future Improvements:

- (1) Implement automated sign convention validation on all trade bookings to flag Buy transactions recorded with positive amounts at the point of entry.
- (2) Introduce a real-time dashboard for pending transaction tracking so that operations analysts can identify settlement delays before they become critical.
- (3) Establish a "time-sensitive transaction" protocol for UHNW clients that pre-identifies available liquidity and alternative funding sources before a major purchase is initiated, rather than discovering shortfalls reactively.
- (4) Conduct quarterly reconciliation audits of transaction sign conventions and formula integrity in financial data reports.

Certificate of Completion

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Dhruv Kamdar **Operations Job Simulation**

Certificate of Completion
August 6th, 2026

Over the period of August 2026, Dhruv Kamdar has completed practical tasks in:

Foundations of operations
Facilitating ultra-high net worth transactions

A handwritten signature in black ink, appearing to read 'Tom Brunskill'.

Tom Brunskill
Co-Founder of Forage

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